On 28 January, resistance came in from the Chinese when the Chinese ambassador to India Sun Weidong posted on Twitter that the WHO did not recommend evacuation of nationals and persuaded the international community to remain calm and not overreact.[29] Meanwhile, on the same day, Chinese president Xi Jinping met with WHO Director-General Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus.[30] While the details of the meeting remain confidential, the next day, on 29 January, Australia, New Zealand, the US and Japan were allowed to run flights to Wuhan in order to evacuate their citizens.[31] [32] [33] [34] Indian diplomats stayed consistently engaged with the Chinese, pressing them for permissions to evacuate our citizens. And on the morning of the 29th, the in-principal approval came in. Each city and each province in China has a Foreign Affairs Office. For matters related to foreigners, embassies must connect with these Foreign Affairs Offices. In addition to connecting with them, the Indian embassy had to then engage with authorities down the chain to the level of provincial authorities so that none of them blocked Indians making their way to the airport. Each point of authority in the chain of command starting from central government authorities, authorities of the Hubei province and Wuhan municipal corporation authorities to even the police had to be looped in and this exercise was aided by the regional Foreign Affairs Office.

On 30 January, WHO Director-General Tedros declared the epidemic a Public Health Emergency of International Concern. The WHO was finally waking up to the tragedy which would soon engulf the world.

The looming task at hand for the Indian diplomats was to get Indians scattered across the city to the airport. Due to the lockdown, free movement was not allowed and people could not be asked to assemble at a certain pickup point or even get to the airport. So, private transport companies were hired who would then be in touch with the staff at the Indian embassy, including Chinese-speaking staff, in order to make logistics and coordination smooth. The Foreign Affairs Office in Wuhan played an important role in this exercise. The formal approval for the airlift came in at 3.30 p.m. on 31 January.[35] Air India, in its preparations, had put one of its Boeing 747 jumbo passenger jets on standby. The 34-member rescue crew that would man the jet included three doctors and four nurses. The visas of all the 34 identified crew members were promptly sent for approval. The Chinese embassy in India was especially helpful in ensuring that all of the crew visas arrived on time. Captain Amitabh Singh, the director of